"SLAP" Tears

Background

- "SLAP'" stands for **S**uperior **L**abrum **A**nterior to **P**osterior and defines the location of a tear from the front to the back of the ring of cartilage that lines your shoulder socket.
- This injury is commonly caused by a fall, direct shoulder impact, or repetitive stress movements such as throwing or overhead pressing. SLAP tears are often seen in overhead athletes, weightlifters, and Service Members.
- Symptoms include deep shoulder pain made worse by reaching overhead or lifting movements. Additional symptoms may include shoulder instability, clicking, and locking or catching. SLAP tears can also occur alongside other shoulder conditions, such as rotator cuff injuries.
- Diagnosis is made through a review of your history, physical exam, and MRI imaging. Additional imaging, such as CT scans or ultrasounds, may be used.
- Treatment involves rehab to improve your range of motion, strength, and overall shoulder function. While some individuals with SLAP tears have minimal pain and can manage effectively without surgery, others experience significant shoulder instability or episodes of locking or catching and may need surgical repair.

Latest Research

- When treated without surgery, patients typically experience reduced pain and improved shoulder function within 6 months and usually get back to normal activities within 12 weeks of beginning physical therapy. High-quality rehabilitation is critical for achieving these outcomes.
- However, if pain persists, injection therapies or surgery may be necessary. Patients under the ages of 40–45 tend to have the best surgical outcomes. Consult with your doctor for personalized advice.

Rehab Instructions

Posterior Capsule Stretching

Sleeper Stretch

1. Start by lying on your side with your affected arm on the bottom. Bend that elbow to a 90-degree angle.
2. Next, use your opposite hand to gently draw your affected forearm towards the table or bed until you feel a mild stretch.
3. Hold the stretch for 30 seconds

Complete 2 sets before moving on to the strength exercises and perform 1 x a day.

Cross-arm Adduction Stretch

1. Hold your affected arm across your body and use your other arm to pull it towards your body until you feel a stretch in your shoulder **(b)**.
2. Do not rotate your upper body.
3. Hold for 15–30 seconds

Complete 3 reps of each stretch 2 x a day.





Scapular Stabilization

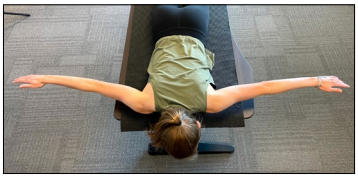
Ts (C)

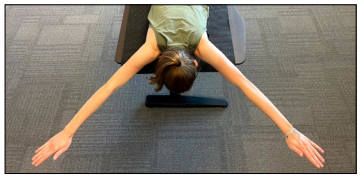
1. Lie face down with your arms straight out at a 90-degree angle to your body and with your palms facing down, forming a "T."
2. Squeeze your shoulder blades together and down as if you're trying to put them into your back pockets.
3. Then, slowly bring your arms up off the floor and towards the ceiling.
4. Hold this position for 5 seconds.

Ts (Y)

1. Lie face down with your arms straight out at about a 45-degree angle to your body with your palms facing down, forming a "Y."
2. Squeeze your shoulder blades together and down as if you're trying to put them into your back pockets.
3. Then, slowly raise your arms up off the floor towards the ceiling.
4. Hold each position for 5 seconds. Perform 2 sets of 10 reps

Complete 2 sets of 10 reps of both C and Y T exercises 1 x a day.





TIPS

- Avoid "hiking up your shoulders." That is, don't bring your shoulders up to your neck.
- You can place a rolled-up towel under your forehead to keep your head off the floor.

Rotator Cuff Strengthening

You'll need a resistance band for these exercises.

Shoulder Scaption (E)

1. Secure the resistance band by putting it under your foot.
2. Hold the resistance band at your side and bring your arm slightly forward.
3. Raise your arm to shoulder height, keeping your elbow straight. You could also, use a 1–3-lb hand weight for resistance instead of a resistance band.
4. Hold for 3 seconds.

Internal Rotation (F)

1. Secure a resistance band at the same height as your elbow by closing it in the hinge side of a door such as a bathroom or bedroom door. When you've closed the band in the door, tug on it to test that it's secure.
2. Put a rolled-up towel under your exercising arm. This helps to keep your elbow aligned with your body and ensures proper form. **(F1)**
3. Hold the free end of the resistance band with your exercising hand and position your hand in front of your stomach, putting tension on the resistance band.
4. Slowly pull the band *towards* your stomach and be careful to not move your elbow. **(F2)**
5. Hold for 3 seconds.

External Rotation (G)



1. Secure a resistance band at the same height as your elbow by closing it in the hinge side of a door such as a bathroom or bedroom door. When you've closed the band in the doo tug on it to test that it's secure.
2. Put a rolled-up towel under your exercising arm. This helps to keep your elbow aligned with your body and ensures proper form. **(G1)**
3. Hold the free end of the resistance band with your exercising hand and position your hand in front of your stomach, putting tension on the resistance band.
4. Slowly pull the band *away* from your stomach and be careful to not move your elbow. **(G2)**
5. Hold for 3 seconds.





Complete 2–3 sets of 10 reps of each exercise 1 x a day.

TIPS

- Keep your upper body facing forward, and don't rotate your upper body while completing these exercises.
- Increase band resistance when these exercises get to be easy and pain-free.
- Stepping further away from the door increases the resistance.

References

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